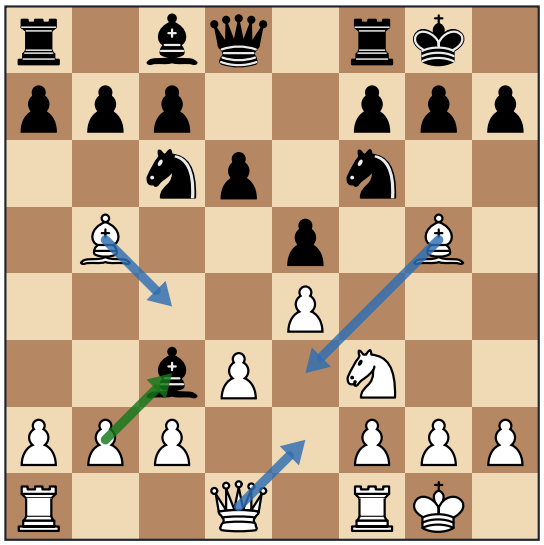
Four Knights Game

ECO C47-C50 | 49 named lines | Open games (1.e4 e5)

In one sentence: Classical open-game theory: rapid development, central tension and king safety decide the game.

Memory pattern: Knights, bishops, castle, then open the center when ahead in development.



Main line: 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 Bb4 5.O-O O-O 6.d3 d6 7.Bg5 Bxc3

Key ideas

1. Develop knights before bishops and castle early.
2. Fight for the center with d4 or ...d5 at the right moment.
3. Use gambit ideas (Scotch, King's Gambit, Vienna) only when you know the follow-up tactics.
4. Avoid pawn grabs that cost tempi; watch f7/f2 weaknesses.
5. Trade pieces when ahead; keep tension when your pieces are more active.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.27** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best: bxc3.

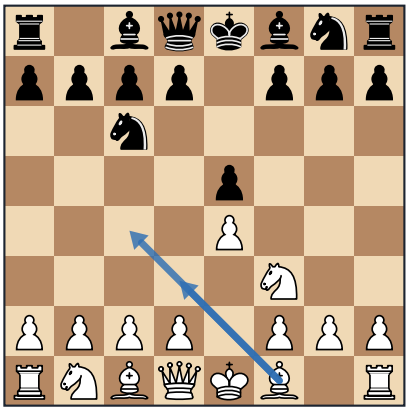
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Open centre: lines open early, so development and king safety dominate. Structures range from open centres to gambit positions.
2. Where does my king go?	Castle early; do not leave the king in the center when lines open.
3. Best minor pieces?	Develop knights then bishops; fight for the center and the f7/f2 squares.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Complete development, castle, then open the center or attack the weak point.
5. What does my opponent want?	The side with the initiative wants to open lines; the defender wants to neutralize with ...d5 or ...Nf6.

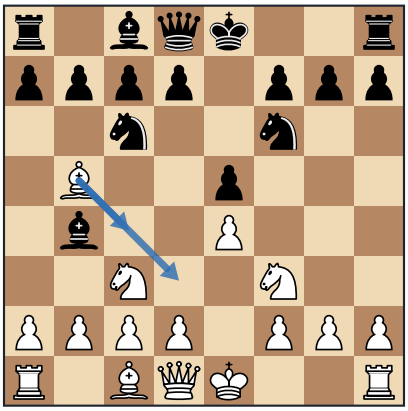
The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 Bb4 5.O-O O-O 6.d3 d6 7.Bg5 Bxc3

Move	Why it is played
1. e4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... e5	Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
2... Nc6	Develops the knight to c6.
3. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.
3... Nf6	Counter e4. Develops the knight to f6.
4. Bb5	Develops the bishop to b5.
4... Bb4	Develops the bishop to b4.
5. O-O	Castles: the king reaches safety and the rook joins the center.
5... O-O	Castles: the king reaches safety and the rook joins the center.
6. d3	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
6... d6	Support e5. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
7. Bg5	Develops the bishop to g5.
7... Bxc3	Captures on c3 to trade or win material.



After 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6



After c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 Bb4

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

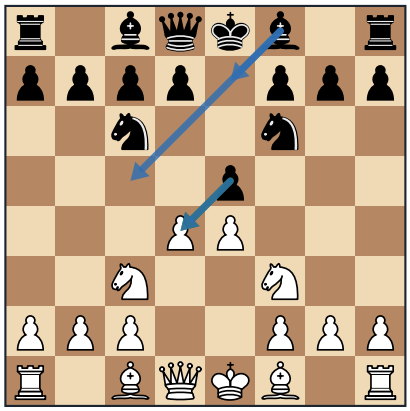


Position after the line

Spanish Variation C48 | 28 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5`

Stockfish: **+0.28** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: Bb4.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Rubinstein Variation, Symmetrical Variation, Double Spanish, Bardeleben Variation

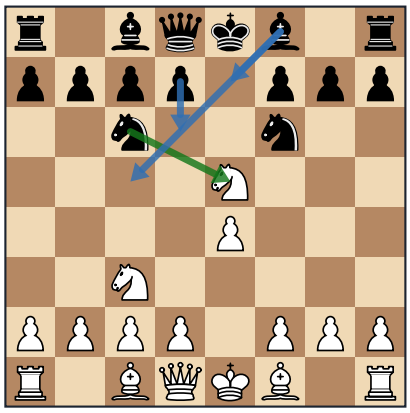


Position after the line

Scotch Variation C47 | 7 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.d4`

Stockfish: **+0.01** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: exd4.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Belgrade Gambit, Krause Gambit, Oxford Gambit, Schmid Defense

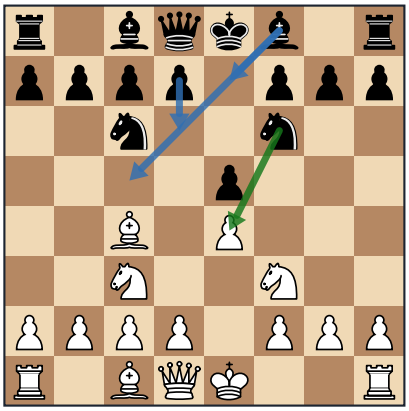


Position after the line

Halloween Gambit C47 | 3 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Nxe5`

Stockfish: **-1.57** (clearly better for Black, depth 17). Best next move: Nxe5.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Oldtimer Variation, Plasma Variation

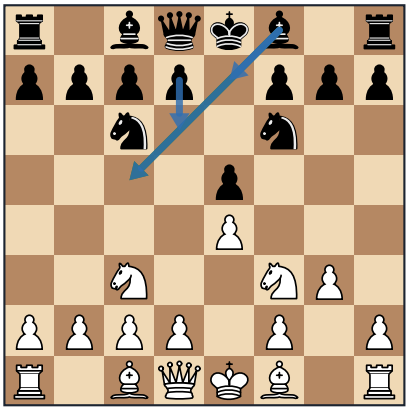


Position after the line

Italian Variation C47 | 3 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6 4.Nc3`

Stockfish: **-0.20** (equal, depth 18). Best next move: Nxe4.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Noa Gambit



Position after the line

Glek System C47 | 2 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.g3`

Stockfish: **-0.14** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: Bc5.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)



Position after the line

Gunsberg Variation C47 | 2 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.a3`

Stockfish: **-0.01** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: d5.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Provincial Opening

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Count your developed pieces versus your opponent's every move. If you are ahead, open the position; if behind, keep it closed or trade.

Why play it

Classical open-game theory: rapid development, central tension and king safety decide the game.

Typical mistakes

- Early queen sorties that lose time.
- Leaving the king in the center when lines are open.
- Grabbing a pawn and falling behind in development.

Typical tactics and traps

- Fried Liver, Legal's Mate and similar f7/f2 tactics.
- Scholar's-style Qh5/Bc4 attacks on f7 if Black ignores them.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Open games reward activity; simplified endings depend on pawn structure and piece activity.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Four Knights Game (all lines)** C47
  `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6`
  - **Glek System** C47
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 -> 4.g3`
  - **Gunsberg Variation** C47
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 -> 4.a3`
    - **Provincial Opening** C47
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.a3 -> 4...d6 5.h3`
  - **Halloween Gambit** C47
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 -> 4.Nxe5`
    - **Oldtimer Variation** C47
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Nxe5 -> 4...Nxe5 5.d4 Ng6 6.e5 Ng8 7.Bc4 Bb4 8.Qf3 f5`
    - **Plasma Variation** C47
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Nxe5 -> 4...Nxe5 5.d4 Nc6 6.d5 Ne5 7.f4 Ng6 8.e5 Ng8 9.d6 cxd6 10.exd6 Qf6 11.…`
  - **Italian Variation** C47
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6 4.Nc3`
    - **Noa Gambit** C47
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6 4.Nc3 -> 4...Nxe4 5.Bxf7`
  - **Naroditsky Variation** C47
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 -> 4.Nd5`
  - **Scotch Variation** C47
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 -> 4.d4`
    - **Belgrade Gambit** C47
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.d4 -> 4...exd4 5.Nd5`
      - **Modern Defense** C47
        `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.d4 exd4 5.Nd5 -> 5...Nxe4 6.Qe2 f5`
    - **Krause Gambit** C47
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.d4 -> 4...Bb4 5.Nxe5`
      - **Leonhardt Defense** C47
        `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.d4 Bb4 5.Nxe5 -> 5...Qe7`
    - **Oxford Gambit** C47
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.d4 -> 4...Bb4 5.d5 Nd4`
    - **Schmid Defense** C47
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.d4 -> 4...exd4 5.Nxd4 Nxe4`
  - **Spanish Variation** C48
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 -> 4.Bb5`
    - **Classical Variation** C48
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 -> 4...Bc5`
    - **Double Spanish** C49
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 -> 4...Bb4`
    - **Rubinstein Variation** C48
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 -> 4...Nd4`
      - **Henneberger Variation** C48
        `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nc3 Nc6 4.Bb5 Nd4 5.O-O`
      - **Marshall Gambit** C48
        `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 Nd4 -> 5.Ba4 Bc5 6.Nxe5 O-O`
      - **Marshall Variation** C48
        `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 Nd4 -> 5.Nxe5 Bc5 6.O-O O-O`
      - **Maróczy Variation** C48
        `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 Nd4 -> 5.Be2 Nxf3 6.Bxf3 Bc5 7.O-O O-O 8.d3 d6 9.Na4 Bb6`
    - **Ranken Variation** C48
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 -> 4...a6 5.Bxc6`
    - **Rubinstein Variation Accepted** C48
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 -> 4...Nd4 5.Nxd4`
    - **Nimzowitsch Variation** C49
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 -> 4...Bb4 5.O-O O-O 6.Bxc6`
    - **Symmetrical Variation** C49
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 -> 4...Bb4 5.O-O O-O 6.d3 d6`

Tarrasch Variation C49
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nc3 Nc6 4.Bb5 Bb4 5.O-O O-O 6.d3 d6 7.Bg5 Be6

Metger Unpin C49
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 Bb4 5.O-O O-O 6.d3 d6 -> 7.Bg5 Bxc3 8.bxc3 Qe7

Blake Variation C49
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 Bb4 5.O-O O-O 6.d3 d6 -> 7.Bg5 Ne7 8.Nh4 c6 9.Bc4 d5 10.Bb3 Qd6

Alatortsev Variation C49
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 -> 4...Bb4 5.O-O O-O 6.d3 Qe7 7.Ne2 d5

Gunsberg Counterattack C49
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nc3 Nc6 4.Bb5 Bb4 5.O-O O-O 6.Nd5 Nxd5 7.exd5 e4

Svenonius Variation C49
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 -> 4...Bb4 5.O-O O-O 6.d3 Bxc3 7.bxc3 d5

Janowski Variation C49
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 -> 4...Bb4 5.O-O O-O 6.d3 Bxc3 7.bxc3 d6 8.Re1

Bardeleben Variation C48
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 -> 4...Bc5 5.O-O O-O 6.Nxe5 Nxe5 7.d4 Bd6 8.f4 Nc6 9.e5 Bb4

Spielmann Variation C48
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 -> 4...a6 5.Bxc6 dxc6 6.Nxe5 Nxe4 7.Nxe4 Qd4 8.O-O Qxe5 9.Re1 Be6 10.d4 Qd5

Scotch Variation Accepted C47
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 -> 4.d4 exd4

Main Line C47
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.d4 exd4 -> 5.Nxd4 Bb4 6.Nxc6 bxc6 7.Bd3 d5 8.exd5 O-O 9.O-O

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bb5 Bb4 5.0-0 0-0
```

Plan chain

White	Nf3 -> Nc3 -> d4 -> Bc4 -> Bd3
Black	Nc6 -> Nf6 -> d5 -> Be7 -> Bc5

Three rules to remember

1. Knights, bishops, castle, then open the center when ahead in development.
2. Complete development, castle, then open the center or attack the weak point.
3. The side with the initiative wants to open lines; the defender wants to neutralize with ...d5 or ...Nf6.

Pawn structure in one line

Open centre: lines open early, so development and king safety dominate. Structures range from open centres to gambit positions.